First Inaugural Address

President Franklin D. Roosevelt · March 4, 1933

Source: Franklin D. Roosevelt, First Inaugural Address (1933). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> Taking office at the depth of the Great Depression, FDR reassured a frightened nation that "the only thing we have to fear is fear itself" and demanded "action, and action now" — even broad executive power — to put people back to work.

This is preeminently the time to speak the truth, the whole truth, frankly and boldly. Nor need we shrink from honestly facing conditions in our country today. This great Nation will endure as it has endured, will revive and will prosper. So, first of all, let me assert my firm belief that the only thing we have to fear is fear itself — nameless, unreasoning, unjustified terror which paralyzes needed efforts to convert retreat into advance.

[. . .]

Our greatest primary task is to put people to work. This is no unsolvable problem if we face it wisely and courageously. It can be accomplished in part by direct recruiting by the Government itself, treating the task as we would treat the emergency of a war, but at the same time, through this employment, accomplishing greatly needed projects to stimulate and reorganize the use of our natural resources.